



WHILE MOST CENTRES ARE LIKELY TO WITNESS RUN-HEAVY CONTESTS, THE THREE VENUES IN JAIPUR COULD ASSIST FAST BOWLERS EARLY, ESPECIALLY AS TEMPERATURES DIP

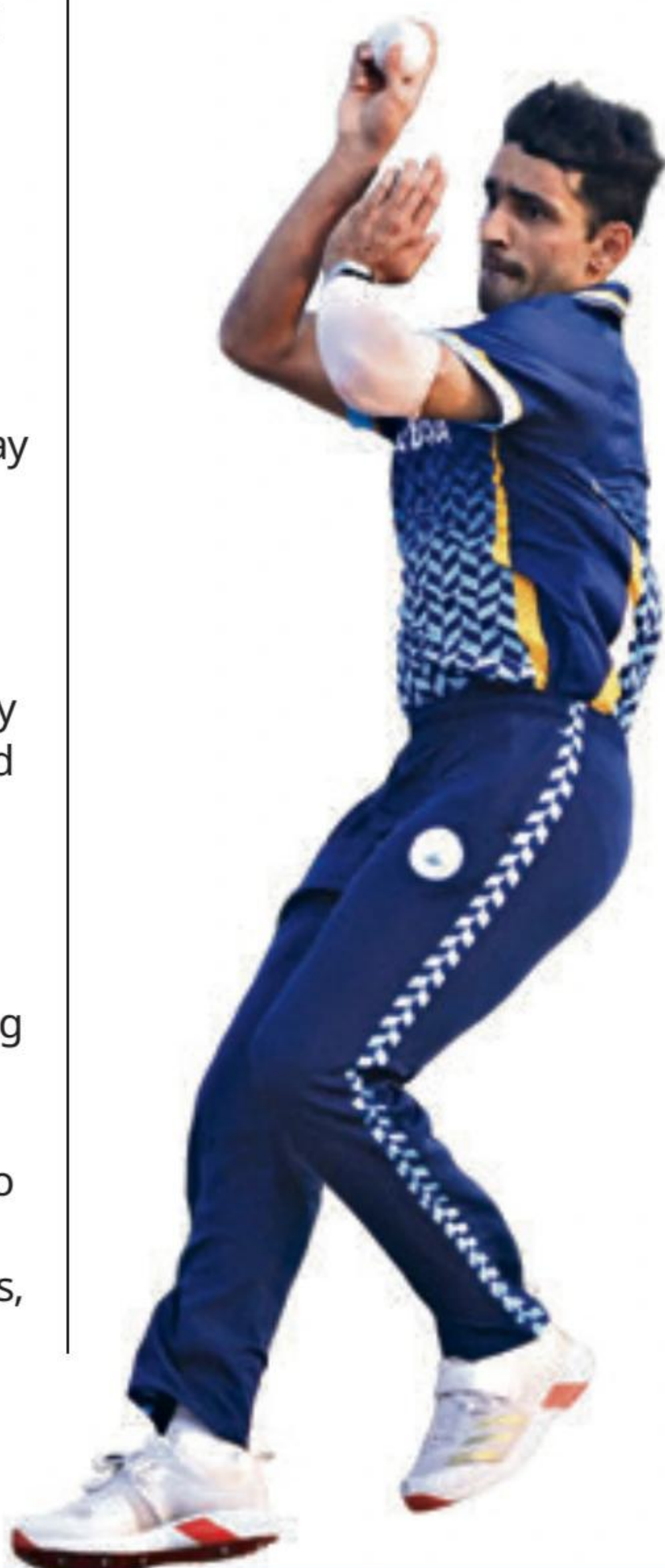
Delhi and Mumbai.

They are unlikely to feature in all seven league games, but their presence will certainly boost their teams and give the tournament a much-needed lift.

The tournament also holds significance for Kohli and Rohit.

In the build-up to the 2027 ODI World Cup, India is scheduled to play 21 ODIs. Given that both Rohit and Kohli have retired from Tests and T20Is, their opportunities in the 50-over format are already limited. Featuring in the Vijay Hazare Trophy would help them find rhythm ahead of India's home ODI series against New Zealand in January and keep their World Cup preparations on track.

Both Rohit and Kohli were among the runs in the recent home series against South Africa, and their availability also allows youngsters to learn directly from them. "They are role models for the young cricketers, so it would be wonderful if they



played. It will boost the morale and motivate the youngsters, if they get to share the dressing room with such players," Sanjay Patil, Mumbai's chief selector, tells *Sportstar*.

"We could win 42 titles for Mumbai because the younger players always had the backing of the seniors. In the

earlier times, legends like Dilip Vengsarkar, Ravi Shastri, Sachin Tendulkar, and Sanjay Manjrekar always made themselves available whenever they were not on national duty," he says.

Yet, the focus is not limited to Rohit and Kohli.

Following the Board's mandate, a pool of international cricketers, including Rishabh Pant, K.L. Rahul, Mohammed Siraj and Yashasvi Jaiswal, is also expected to turn up, adding further depth to the competition. While Jaiswal and Siraj have featured in the Syed Mushtaq Ali T20 Trophy, for Rahul, Pant and a few others, it will mark a return to the domestic circuit after a hiatus. Meaningful contributions here could help them settle into rhythm ahead of a busy international calendar.

For the selectors, too, the tournament offers a fresh perspective. With the ODI World Cup still a year-and-a-half away, the Ajit Agarkar-led committee can closely track young performers who have

Sustained readiness: Anshul Kamboj, one of many fast bowlers balancing opportunity with workload as formats blur into one another. K. V. S. GIRI